

often ranges over two octaves, frequently leaping suddenly from a low note to a high, varying its short phrases and motifs, and lingering on one syllable as it ascends and descends.”

“ I am the **fiery life** of divine substance, **I blaze** above... the fields, **I shine** in the waters, **I burn** in the sun, moon, and stars.
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HILDEGARD OF BINGEN

Hildegard’s compositions extend from flamboyant early works and sensual pieces to the more restrained chants of later years. Rooted in liturgical practice and dated between c. 1140 and c. 1160, they include devotional songs, antiphons, elaborate responsories, hymns, and sequences for the Mass. Her most famous compositions are her version of opera, *Ordo virtutum* (Order of the Virtues, c. 1150)—a morality play set to music, with 82 melodies—and her 77 liturgical chants, *Symphonia armonie celestium revelationum* (Symphony of the Harmony of Heavenly Revelations, c. 1158).

According to Christopher Page, a scholar of medieval music, “We don’t know if Hildegard is sitting and humming the songs, or if she’s perhaps humming and writing them down on a white tablet, with a final version then being written by someone else on slate or parchment ... We don’t know if the words come first, or if the words and the music grow together in an organic